

# Heuristic Evaluation Report

System Under Review: Course Discussion Board Interface & Content Editor

| ID | Interface Location                     | Description of the Usability Issue                                                                                                                                                                                  | Heuristic(s) Violated                                       | Severity |
|----|----------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------|----------|
| 1  | Post Editor → Cancel Button            | Clicking the "Cancel" button instantly deletes the entire active draft without triggering any confirmation modal. Users risk losing significant work from accidental clicks.                                        | H3: User Control and Freedom                                | 3        |
| 2  | Discussion Thread Form → Submit Action | Submitting a post with an empty "Title" field causes a full page reload and strips out any previously uploaded text or formatting, forcing the user to completely restart from scratch.                             | H5: Error Prevention<br>H9: Recover from Errors             | 3        |
| 3  | Post Editor → Image Insert Dialog      | Entering a broken, non-existent, or restricted image URL does not trigger a validation warning. The system submits successfully but displays a broken image placeholder in the final published thread.              | H5: Error Prevention                                        | 3        |
| 4  | Discussion Forum → New Thread UI       | When navigating to "Week 6" discussions, the primary action button ("New Thread") is placed at the bottom right under existing threads. This requires explicit scrolling on smaller laptop displays.                | H1: Visibility of System Status                             | 2        |
| 5  | Rich Text Toolbar → Blockquote Tool    | The blockquote function utilizes an abstract geometric symbol instead of standard text-editor formatting iconography (like standard quote marks), causing ambiguity for new users.                                  | H4: Consistency and Standards                               | 2        |
| 6  | Thread Reply UI → Nested Answers       | The interface allows deep nesting of replies, but the margin indentations shrink excessively. After four levels, the text becomes constrained into narrow, vertical strips that are impossible to read comfortably. | H8: Aesthetic and Minimalist Design                         | 2        |
| 7  | Forum Help → Search Bar                | The "Help" documentation opens up an exhaustive repository of general course platform rules rather than contextual interface tips. It lacks filter settings or a localized text search option.                      | H10: Help and Documentation                                 | 2        |
| 8  | Form Validation → Error Alerts         | When an error occurs during submission, the system generates a small alert bar showing raw error text ("Error 400: Bad Parameter") rather than an actionable, human-readable correction message.                    | H9: Help Users Recognize, Diagnose, and Recover from Errors | 2        |

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|----|-----------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------|----------|
| 9  | Rich Text Editor → Live Workspace | The fonts, spacing, and header sizing displayed within the editing viewport do not accurately mirror the layout of the final submitted post. This disrupts visual expectations.                 | H4: Consistency and Standards         | 1        |
| 10 | Thread Footer → Follow Button     | Toggling the "Follow" button to subscribe to thread updates provides only a slight shift in font weight rather than a distinct color alteration or explicit checkmark icon.                     | H1: Visibility of System Status       | 1        |
| 11 | Rich Text Toolbar → Hotkeys       | Standard industry key combinations for secondary operations (e.g., Ctrl+K to evoke the hyperlink modal) are completely unsupported within the text block, requiring explicit mouse interaction. | H7: Flexibility and Efficiency of Use | 1        |